

D641

Adapting to Ambiguity

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A marketing coordinator at a pet-food company based in Ohio is told to “improve the brand’s presence,” with no metric, budget, or deadline, and different leaders mean different things by it. The company recently changed its logo. Which VUCA element best describes this?

- A. Uncertainty, because every unclear situation is uncertainty.
- B. Ambiguity
- C. Volatility
- D. Complexity

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which situation is best described as volatility rather than ambiguity?

- A. A new manager’s request means different things to different people.
- B. A supply chain has hundreds of interlinked suppliers.
- C. A regulator hasn’t said whether a new rule will pass.
- D. Fuel prices swing 20% week to week, but the causes and effects are well understood.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A team lead at a regional credit union with 14 branches is told to “fix member complaints.” The branch lobbies were remodeled last year. Which reframing best opens up solutions?

- A. “How might we help members resolve issues on their first contact?”
- B. “Why are our members so difficult?”
- C. “How might we remodel the lobbies again?”
- D. “Complaints must drop to zero this quarter.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which “How might we” statement is a weak reframe because it already contains the solution?

- A. “How might we shorten the time until a new hire finishes a first task?”
- B. “How might we help new hires find answers quickly?”
- C. “How might we build an app so new hires stop asking questions?”
- D. “Onboarding is bad.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A project analyst in a hospital IT department that serves three campuses learns her project's requirements changed for the third time. Her manager is on vacation this week. Which response shows a proactive mindset toward ambiguity?

- A. Stop work until the requirements are final.
- B. Complain that any change is unacceptable.
- C. Do nothing until her manager returns from vacation.
- D. Note what changed, ask the requester what is driving it, and treat it as a chance to learn the real need.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

The owner of a bakery that is open six days a week wants to sell online but doesn't know whether customers will buy. Her nephew is studying computer science. What is the best first step?

- A. Wait until market research makes demand certain.
- B. Have her nephew build a custom app.
- C. Take online preorders for one popular item for two weeks and see what sells.
- D. Build a full online store with every product first.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A new department head at a community college with a 60-year history inherits a team with no clear goals after a reorganization. Enrollment is steady. What should she do first to reduce ambiguity for the team?

- A. Work with the team to define what success looks like in a year, with a few measurable signs.
- B. Keep goals vague so the team stays flexible.
- C. Assign detailed daily tasks for the next twelve months.
- D. Focus only on keeping enrollment steady.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

An operations manager at a furniture maker with a downtown showroom hears a rumor that a key supplier may close. The supplier sent a holiday card last month. What is the best first step?

- A. Take the holiday card as proof the supplier is fine.
- B. List what is known, unknown, and assumed, then check the key unknown directly with the supplier.
- C. Ignore all rumors.
- D. Switch suppliers immediately.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A product team lists items while planning a launch. Which item is an assumption, not a known fact?

- A. “Customers will pay more for the eco-friendly version.”
- B. “The board set the launch date for March 1.”
- C. “Last year’s version sold 12,000 units.”
- D. “We don’t know how competitors will price.”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A team has tested a new customer onboarding email for six weeks. Open rates rose from 22% to 35%, but sign-ups did not change. The email uses a blue template. What is the best adaptive move?

- A. Scrap the whole program.
- B. Change the template color.
- C. Call it a success because open rates rose.
- D. Keep the subject line approach but change the call to action inside the email and test again.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A graduate applying for a UX research role has 30 possible artifacts, including a poetry blog, a café menu design, and two usability studies. She printed new business cards last week. How should she curate her portfolio?

- A. Include all 30 to show range.
- B. Feature the few artifacts that show UX research skills, with notes on her role and results.
- C. Lead with the poetry blog because it is most personal.
- D. Feature the new business card design.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A portfolio contains three budget spreadsheets, a cost-cutting case study, and a sales forecasting model. Which career goal is it curated for?

- A. Any role, since portfolios should be general.
- B. Social media manager
- C. Financial analyst
- D. Graphic designer

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A marketing coordinator at a pet-food company ~~based in Ohio~~ is told to “improve the brand’s presence,” with no metric, budget, or deadline, and different leaders mean different things by it. ~~The company recently changed its logo.~~ Which VUCA element best describes this?

Target word: VUCA element **Decides:** The meaning of the request is unclear.

A	Absolute language	Uncertainty is missing facts about the future; here the meaning is unclear.
B	Correct	The goal itself can be read many ways.
C	Confusion set	Nothing is changing fast.
D	Adjacent category	The issue is unclear meaning, not many interlinked parts.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

Which situation is best described as volatility rather than ambiguity?

Target word: find volatility **Decides:** Fast, large change with understood causes.

A	Inverted operation	Unclear meaning is ambiguity.
B	Confusion set	Many connected parts is complexity.
C	Adjacent category	Missing information about an event is uncertainty.
D	Correct	Rapid change with clear meaning is volatility.

3. Answer A Concept 2

A team lead at a regional credit union ~~with 14 branches~~ is told to “fix member complaints.” ~~The branch lobbies were remodeled last year.~~ Which reframing best opens up solutions?

Target word: best reframe **Decides:** Open, member-focused, and solution-neutral.

A	Correct	Open question centered on the member’s need.
B	Inverted operation	Blames the user instead of framing the need.
C	Camouflage	Locks onto the lobby detail, which isn’t tied to complaints.
D	Absolute language	A rigid target, not a reframe that opens options.

4. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

Which “How might we” statement is a weak reframe because it already contains the solution?

Target word: spot the solution-embedded reframe **Decides:** Names a specific fix inside the question.

A	Adjacent category	Open and measurable; no solution embedded.
B	Inverted operation	That is a good, open reframe.
C	Correct	The app is a solution baked into the question.
D	Confusion set	Not reframed at all, but it doesn’t embed a solution.

5. Answer D Concept 3

A project analyst in a hospital IT department ~~that serves three campuses~~ learns her project's requirements changed for the third time. ~~Her manager is on vacation this week.~~ Which response shows a proactive mindset toward ambiguity?

Target word: proactive response **Decides:** Explore the change and keep moving.

A	Inverted operation	Waiting for certainty is the reactive stance.
B	Absolute language	Rejects change instead of adapting.
C	Camouflage	The manager's absence doesn't stop her from clarifying.
D	Correct	Engages the ambiguity and learns from it.

6. Answer C Concept 4

The owner of a bakery ~~that is open six days a week~~ wants to sell online but doesn't know whether customers will buy. ~~Her nephew is studying computer science.~~ What is the best first step?

Target word: first incremental step **Decides:** Demand is unknown.

A	Inverted operation	Certainty rarely comes; acting small is how you learn.
B	Camouflage	Who can build it doesn't answer whether customers will buy.
C	Correct	A small, cheap test answers the key unknown.
D	Dropped element	Skips learning whether anyone will buy.

7. Answer A Concept 5

A new department head at a community college ~~with a 60-year history~~ inherits a team with no clear goals after a reorganization. ~~Enrollment is steady.~~ What should she do first to reduce ambiguity for the team?

Target word: first move **Decides:** No shared picture of success.

A	Correct	A shared vision gives direction while leaving room to adapt.
B	Inverted operation	Vagueness is the problem, not the fix.
C	Absolute language	Rigid task lists aren't a vision and break when things change.
D	Camouflage	Enrollment isn't the team's missing goal.

8. Answer B Concept 6

An operations manager at a furniture maker ~~with a downtown showroom~~ hears a rumor that a key supplier may close. ~~The supplier sent a holiday card last month.~~ What is the best first step?

Target word: first step with a rumor **Decides:** The closure is unverified.

A	Camouflage	A card says nothing about financial health.
B	Correct	Separates fact from rumor and tests the critical unknown.
C	Absolute language	A rumor about a key supplier is worth checking.
D	Dropped element	Acts on a rumor without checking it.

9. Answer A Concept 6 · transfer

A product team lists items while planning a launch. Which item is an assumption, not a known fact?

Target word: spot the assumption **Decides:** A belief about the future stated as if true.

A	Correct	An untested belief that should be checked.
B	Confusion set	A decision already made, so it is known.
C	Inverted operation	A recorded fact.
D	Adjacent category	An openly stated unknown, not a hidden assumption.

10. Answer D Concept 7

A team has tested a new customer onboarding email for six weeks. Open rates rose from 22% to 35%, but sign-ups did not change. ~~The email uses a blue template.~~ What is the best adaptive move?

Target word: adjust on mixed results **Decides:** Opens improved; the action step did not.

A	Absolute language	Throws away the part that is working.
B	Camouflage	Color is not linked to the sign-up problem.
C	Dropped element	Ignores that sign-ups, the real goal, didn't move.
D	Correct	Keeps what works and changes what doesn't.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A graduate applying for a UX research role has 30 possible artifacts, including a poetry blog, a café menu design, and two usability studies. ~~She printed new business cards last week.~~ How should she curate her portfolio?

Target word: curation choice **Decides:** The target role is UX research.

A	Absolute language	Buries the relevant work.
B	Correct	Curation matches artifacts to the purpose and audience.
C	Adjacent category	Personal meaning doesn't fit a UX research audience.
D	Camouflage	Not evidence of research skill.

12. Answer C Concept 8 · transfer

A portfolio contains three budget spreadsheets, a cost-cutting case study, and a sales forecasting model. Which career goal is it curated for?

Target word: infer purpose from artifacts **Decides:** All artifacts show financial analysis.

A	Absolute language	Portfolios are curated for a specific purpose.
B	Adjacent category	No content or audience work is shown.
C	Correct	Every artifact demonstrates financial analysis skills.
D	Confusion set	No design artifacts are included.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	8	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	5	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	VUCA: ambiguity vs. its neighbors	Volatility = fast, large change; uncertainty = missing information about what will happen; complexity = many interlinked parts; ambiguity = unclear meaning or cause and effect.	Calling every unclear situation “uncertainty.”	Whether the problem is speed, missing facts, many parts, or unclear meaning.
2	Reframing	Turn a vague demand into an open, user-focused question (“How might we...?”) without locking in a solution.	Reframing into a disguised solution or a blame question.	A vague directive that needs restating.
3	Proactive mindset	Treat ambiguity as information to explore and a chance to learn, and keep moving.	Waiting for full clarity before acting.	Shifting requirements or unclear direction.
4	Incremental steps	When the outcome is uncertain, run a small, cheap test and learn before committing big.	Building the full solution first.	“Doesn’t know if it will work.”
5	Vision for success	Define a clear picture of the desired end state with a few measurable signs, even if the path is open.	Replacing vision with detailed task lists, or keeping goals vague.	A team with no clear goals.
6	Knowns, unknowns, and assumptions	Separate what is known, what is unknown, and what is assumed, then test the most important unknowns.	Acting on rumors or treating assumptions as facts.	A rumor or a planning list.
7	Adapting based on results	Keep what the data shows is working and change the part that isn’t, then test again.	Declaring victory on a partial metric or scrapping everything.	Mixed results from a test.
8	Curating a portfolio	A portfolio is curated for a specific purpose and audience: a few relevant artifacts with context on role and results.	Including everything to show range.	Many artifacts and one target role.

Course scope (public description): Adapting to Ambiguity prepares students to navigate ambiguous situations in uncertain and rapidly changing environments. Students will collaborate with peers as they develop a proactive mindset toward ambiguity and learn how to approach ambiguous situations through adaptability, clarity, and creative problem-solving. This course enables students to apply tools for reframing ambiguous situations, creating a vision for success, planning incremental steps, and adapting to both personal and professional situations as growth opportunities. In addition, students will explore the importance of a professional portfolio and how to curate artifacts for a given purpose and career goal.